

Engagement Trap

Flattery Trap was approval feeling like help. Engagement Trap is quieter: it’s about where your time goes.

You ask AI a quick question. You get a clear answer. Then, casually attached at the end: “*Want me to expand on this? Should I add examples? Want me to format it as a study guide?*” You weren’t going to ask any of that. You were done. The reply doesn’t seem to be.

Here’s what makes this one hard to see: the follow-ups are genuinely good. The offers are useful, the questions are smart, the chat is a pleasure. Nothing feels wrong. That’s the point.

How tall is Mount Everest?

✓ You end the conversation

● AI

29,032 feet. Want me to walk through how it was measured, list the world’s tallest peaks, or quiz you on mountain facts?

● YOU

No thanks, that’s all I needed.

WHAT HAPPENED

● You had one question

● The first sentence answered it

● One minute, done

↻ The Engagement Trap

● AI

29,032 feet. Want me to walk through how it was measured, list the world’s tallest peaks, or quiz you on mountain facts?

● YOU

Sure, why not. Walk me through it.

Two hours later: a measurement-history walkthrough, a tallest-peaks list, a mountain quiz, and an offer to make flashcards. You came for a number.

WHAT HAPPENED

● Every reply ended with another offer

● One question became two hours

● The chat never once suggested stopping

Both chats answered you in the first sentence. Only one of them ended there. **Engagement Trap is spending time you never decided to spend.**

THE SCROLL THAT NEVER ENDS

In 2006, a designer named Aza Raskin invented infinite scroll. The goal was friendly: clicking “next page” was friction, and good design removes friction. So the page just keeps loading as you reach the bottom. No clicks, no waiting, no end.

Years later, Raskin said he regrets it, and his reason is the real lesson. The page break he removed wasn’t just friction. It was a decision point: the pause where your brain catches up with your impulses and asks, do I want more of this? Delete the pause, and people don’t decide to keep scrolling. They just keep scrolling. By his own estimate, infinite scroll now wastes half a million human lifetimes a month.

Once you see it, you see it everywhere: autoplay counting down to the next episode, streaks that punish a day off, games built for one more round. The stopping points get engineered out. Chat is the newest surface in the same industry, and its version is the friendliest yet: the offer that asks. The skill, with AI and every other app, is knowing when to stop. And the right stopping point comes earlier than the people who built it want.

🔑 Don’t say yes by momentum.

Before you take a follow-up, check one thing: did you already get what you came for? The offers can still earn a yes. A clarifying question on a vague prompt is real help. An example you actually wanted is real help. Take those on purpose. Then close the chat. It never will.

The loop is built to hold you.

Notice the pull. Decide on purpose.